

IN PROFILE

Pierre Bernac

Poulenc was a hugely accomplished pianist, and performed and recorded many of his own works. In the 1920s, he began a musical partnership with the young singer Pierre Bernac, who, like Poulenc himself, was born in Paris in 1899. Bernac's light baritone voice was suited to the French chanson (song), and early in his career he began performing Poulenc's songs, including the premiere of the *Chansons gaillardes*.

Poulenc was greatly impressed by Bernac's interpretation of his music, and in the 1930s became his accompanist in a series of recitals, tours, and recordings of the many songs that Poulenc had written for him, continuing until Bernac's retirement in 1960.

It is tempting to ascribe the two key aspects of Francis Poulenc's music, the serious and the light, to his parents: his father was a successful industrialist and a devout Catholic; his mother a bohemian amateur pianist with an eclectic taste in music. Francis was born in Paris in 1899. The expectation was that he would pursue a career in the family's pharmaceutical business, and so he had little formal musical education. However, he did take piano lessons with Spanish pianist Ricardo Viñes.

Inspiration and early work

When Poulenc's parents died in his teenage years, Viñes became a key figure in his life. Through Viñes, he met the eccentric composer Erik